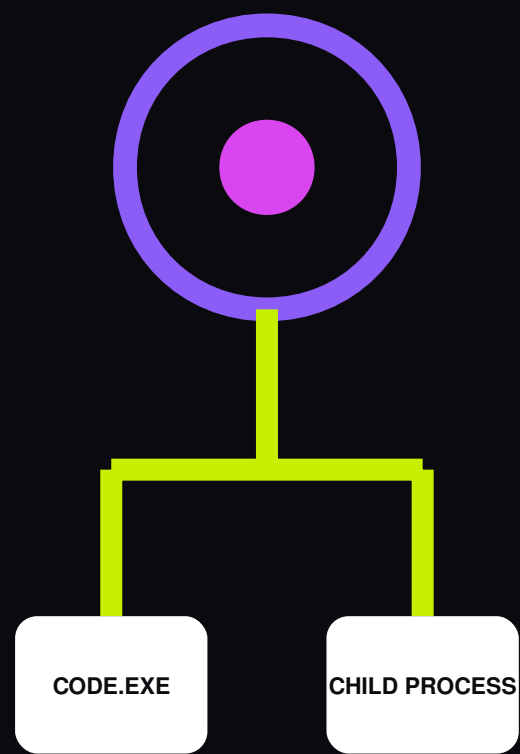


VS CODE TRUSTED- PROJECT CHILD PROCESS VALIDATION

Validates whether processes launched by Visual Studio Code tasks are represented with a direct Code.exe parent and retain sufficient command-line context for later behavioral detection.

VALIDATION QUERY

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM



EVIDENCE BEFORE ALERTING

REPORT DATE	STATUS
22 September 2026	Untested implementation sketch
PRIMARY PLATFORM	OPERATIONAL VALUE
Microsoft Defender XDR	9.7 / 10



EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Decision, confidence and evidence boundary.

ASSESSMENT

OPERATIONAL VALUE

9.7

Validates whether processes launched by Visual Studio Code tasks are represented with a direct Code.exe parent and retain sufficient command-line context for later behavioral detection.

STATUS

Validation query

Untested implementation sketch; Confidence Medium.

1primary table

0joins

0secondary rules

2validation gates

Evidence boundary

A result proves only that Code.exe initiated a process. It does not prove that a malicious repository was opened, Workspace Trust was bypassed, a task used runOn folderOpen, malware executed, credentials were stolen, or WaterPlum was responsible.



BEHAVIOR AND EVIDENCE

Observed facts separated from analytical scope.

MECHANICS

Source-supported fact

- 1 A joint government advisory published on 18 September 2026 describes WaterPlum using malicious Visual Studio Code projects during fake technical interviews.
- 2 The advisory states that project configuration, including `.vscode/tasks.json`, can trigger malware automatically when the project is opened and trusted.
- 3 Official Visual Studio Code documentation confirms that tasks may execute shell or process commands and that `runOn` set to `folderOpen` can start them automatically in a trusted workspace.

Detection hypothesis

If an attacker causes a trusted Visual Studio Code project task to execute, endpoint telemetry should show the resulting process lineage and command context. Distinction requires a controlled task test, project provenance and an inventory of legitimate developer workflows.

Unconfirmed elements

A result proves only that `Code.exe` initiated a process. It does not prove that a malicious repository was opened, Workspace Trust was bypassed, a task used `runOn folderOpen`, malware executed, credentials were stolen, or WaterPlum was responsible.

Logic: Behavioral telemetry validation **ATT&CK:** T1204.002



TELEMETRY CONTRACT

Collection prerequisites and field reliability.

TELEMETRY

REQUIRED

Microsoft Defender for Endpoint process-creation telemetry in DeviceProcessEvents with initiating-process identity and command lines populated.

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT

Workspace path and repository origin, .vscode/tasks.json file telemetry, Workspace Trust policy, signer/hash, developer-role inventory, network connections, and controlled test evidence.

Fields	Reliability	Use
Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName	Documented	Query or triage
FileName, FolderPath, ProcessCommandLine	Documented	Query or triage
InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine	Documented	Query or triage
ProcessUniqueld, InitiatingProcessUniqueld, ReportId	Documented	Query or triage
Code.exe as direct parent of task command	Environment-dependent	Query or triage

Excluded

No message body, phishing-page content, inferred success, actor attribution, or undocumented cross-SIEM mapping is used.



PRIMARY KQL

Direct source-supported conditions with investigable output.

VALIDATION

STATUS

Validation query — Untested implementation sketch

KQL — UNTESTED

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where InitiatingProcessFileName =~ "Code.exe"
| project Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName, AccountName,
           FileName, FolderPath, ProcessCommandLine,
           InitiatingProcessCommandLine,
           InitiatingProcessUniqueId, ProcessUniqueId, ReportId
| order by Timestamp desc
```

WINDOW	THRESHOLD	JOIN	KEY
None	None	None	Process lineage



TRIAGE AND TUNING

Human validation before response.

WORKFLOW

1

Preserve

Retain the process event, unique process identifiers, command lines, account, device and timestamp.

2

Confirm

Identify the developer, workspace origin, task definition and authorized tooling owner.

3

Enrich

Workspace path and repository origin, .vscode/tasks.json file telemetry, Workspace Trust policy, signer/hash, developer-role inventory, network connections, and controlled test evidence.

4

Scope

Review adjacent file creation, repository origin, network activity and child-process descendants.

Expected benign overlap

Normal build, test, debug and lint tasks; integrated terminals; extensions; package managers; compilers; developer scripts; CI tooling invoked from an interactive editor. The query deliberately returns the full population for schema and overlap measurement.

Response boundary

A result proves only that Code.exe initiated a process. It does not prove that a malicious repository was opened, Workspace Trust was bypassed, a task used runOn folderOpen, malware executed, credentials were stolen, or WaterPlum was responsible.



VALIDATION GATES

Controlled tests and cross-SIEM limits.

QUALITY CONTROL

Validation steps

- 1. Open a controlled trusted workspace containing a benign folderOpen task and preserve the resulting process tree.
- 2. Repeat in Restricted Mode and confirm that automatic task execution is suppressed.
- 3. Verify whether Code.exe is the direct parent and whether both command lines and unique process identifiers are populated.
- 4. Inventory legitimate Code.exe child processes over an agreed baseline period before proposing filters or alert logic.

Decision criteria

Success: The controlled folderOpen task is observable with stable parent-child attribution and sufficient context, and legitimate task families can be assigned to owners.

Rejection: Task execution is not attributable to Code.exe, required command-line context is absent, or legitimate activity cannot be distinguished without unsupported assumptions.

Failure: Defender for Endpoint is not deployed, process telemetry is incomplete, command lines are suppressed, or non-Windows VS Code processes use a different image name.

Platform	Decision	Missing evidence
Defender XDR	Validation query	Controlled task test and baseline
Splunk	No reliable implementation	Index, sourcetype, parser, sample
Chronicle	No reliable implementation	Parser and exact UDM mapping



CONCLUSION AND REFERENCES

Coverage statement and document control.

FINAL

CONCLUSION

Validation query

Validates whether processes launched by Visual Studio Code tasks are represented with a direct Code.exe parent and retain sufficient command-line context for later behavioral detection.

A result proves only that Code.exe initiated a process. It does not prove that a malicious repository was opened, Workspace Trust was bypassed, a task used runOn folderOpen, malware executed, credentials were stolen, or WaterPlum was responsible.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1204.002

References

1. NPA, NCO, FBI, DC3, ACSC, BND and BfV — WaterPlum / Contagious Interview advisory — 18 Sep 2026
2. Microsoft — Visual Studio Code Workspace Trust — accessed 22 Sep 2026
3. Microsoft — Visual Studio Code Tasks — accessed 22 Sep 2026
4. Microsoft — DeviceProcessEvents schema — accessed 22 Sep 2026
5. MITRE ATT&CK — T1204.002

Document control

English dossier. No customer data. URLs are defanged in references.txt. HTML and rendering assets remain private.